

Chapter 79 - Smile

When she opened her eyes again, her body emanated a faint white light. That radiance, like ice and snow, flowed from her fingertips, converging into a thread that wound its way into Ning Fuyi's brow. The sleeping Ning Fuyi suddenly raised her chin.

Sweat immediately seeped out, condensing into dewdrops on her ghostly pale skin. She seemed to be suffering some pain as she gritted her teeth.

Chu Qingqiu didn't look away, only gazing deeply at her, then raised her hand and directed that thread into her own mind as well.

She let out a low hum and nearly fell onto Ning Fuyi, having to grip the edge of the bed tightly.

Ning Fuyi's breathing became increasingly rapid. She struggled in her dazed state. Due to the poison-avoiding pill, she could see those wisps of white light, and also see a graceful figure in the soft white glow.

That person slowly rose and sat on her bed. Rich floral fragrance continuously entered her nostrils, surpassing even Mo Qihuai's but not repelling her in the slightest.

Instead, it was like sweet rain falling on parched earth, making her desire to draw even closer.

The thread in her mind bit by bit penetrated her sea of consciousness, making her whole body tingle and ache. She had no choice but to clench her palm, and found herself grasping those soft fingers, feeling that person startle and suddenly tense up.

Though Ning Fuyi's body was unconscious, her divine consciousness was surprisingly clear. She forcibly endured the aching sensation and loosened her grip, pretending to still be unconscious.

Only then did that body slowly relax, and white and pink points of light surged from both their brows, carrying soft halos as they spiraled upward through the air.

Chu Qingqiu hadn't practiced such techniques for a long time. She struggled to control their divine consciousnesses as they intertwined and approached, but they could never merge. In the end, she was almost completely drained of strength, breathing heavily.

"Ning Fuyi..." she called out softly, "Are you unwilling? Or is the power within your body still rejecting me?"

The blood drained from Chu Qingqiu's face, her lips also turning pale, stained with sweat as if truly covered with a layer of frost. She silently recited the incantation and tried to merge again, but her mind felt as if pierced by electric current.

The current flowed from her divine consciousness through her entire body. She suddenly spat out a mouthful of blood, fresh blood overflowing from her mouth, dripping onto Ning Fuyi.

At the same time, Ning Fuyi also raised her head again, painfully gritting her teeth. Blue veins suddenly bulged on her smooth forehead as she uttered several dream-like words, turning her face to one side.

Chu Qingqiu hadn't expected it to be so difficult. Seeing their divine consciousnesses about to return to their bodies, she hurriedly exerted her power again to control them, not bothering to wipe the blood from the corner of her lips.

"What exactly is happening? Are you truly so unwilling? If it were Mo Qihuai instead, would you be willing then?" Chu Qingqiu's words carried a crying tone. She bit her lips tightly, swallowing all the bloody taste, and exerted her power again.

She had never been so stubborn before, refusing to give up no matter what.

"Didn't you say anyone would do? Why can't I, why can't I..." Chu Qingqiu's tears couldn't help but fall from her eyes, mixing with the blood on her clothes, soaking through her white robes.

Once again, she lost her composure because of Ning Fuyi.

She recklessly recited that incantation again. Ning Fuyi immediately felt a cold silver thread spread from her divine consciousness throughout her body. Wherever the silver thread reached, those parts began to tremble.

She had never felt so helpless before. Her body was still unconscious, unable to move except for her right hand. Though her divine consciousness was awake, she couldn't control it either.

She wanted to say "I'm not unwilling" but couldn't speak.

That strange sensation almost made her feel like her heart was being torn apart. Ning Fuyi bit her tongue until it bled, her mouth filled with the taste of blood. The two forces in her sea of consciousness seemed to oppose each other, madly surging through her mind. The pain that had just been suppressed by Chu Qingqiu came knocking again. Ning Fuyi wanted to cry out but couldn't, only able to breathe desperately as a substitute for screaming.

Seeing her body begin to tremble, her green robes disheveled, her fair skin soaked with sweat, and drops of blood falling on her face - the red and white contrasting to make each other strikingly vivid.

The barrier blocked all sounds and scents from the outside world. In the small wooden house, only their warm breaths intertwined, and the gauze curtains around the bed posts swayed without wind.

Ning Fuyi used her remaining will to forcibly raise her right hand, fumbling to grasp Chu Qingqiu's sleeve.

Then with a forceful pull, the already swaying Chu Qingqiu suddenly fell forward, her hand bracing against the jade pillow, her lips barely brushing past Ning Fuyi's cheek.

The warm sensation stunned them both. Ning Fuyi clenched her right hand in her unconscious state, while Chu Qingqiu froze in place, her wet eyelashes blinking.

She looked down at Ning Fuyi's face, judging whether the other was awake, but those eyes were tightly closed, clearly still unconscious.

Her gaze slowly slid down, falling on those lips that were beautiful like rose petals.

These lips were somewhat dry now, but it didn't affect their shape. Though tightly closed, she could imagine how they looked when they smiled, with their pointed corners.

Chu Qingqiu lowered her head to wipe the blood from her lips, hesitating as she slowly moved downward. Finally, she closed her eyes and gently covered them. Both their lips were like sweet fruit, instantly filling with blood, red and alluring.

The hidden red cord simultaneously appeared between both their fingers.

Ning Fuyi clenched her palm, then opened it when those soft fingers approached, allowing her five fingers to slip through and interlock with hers.

At this moment, the pain in her mind seemed insignificant. What made her more uncomfortable was her heartbeat - each beat felt like it would burst her entire chest cavity. Her rapid breathing made her almost unable to breathe, leaving her dazed and confused.

The light gauze around the bed fluttered down, covering their pressed-together bodies and the faint glow emanating from their skin.

The sweet taste of blood bloomed on both their tongues. Above their heads, the two points of light that had been unable to approach suddenly came together and merged. Chu Qingqiu nearly cried out, her body suddenly rolling aside.

Finally, the two trees appeared before her eyes. Indeed, as Jiang Li had said, one was normal while the other bore black demonic fruit. More fruit had already cracked open, roots extending into the soil. The entire tree was like a demon reaching out clawed hands to tear at hearts, extremely terrifying.

Demonic energy had already overflowed. Chu Qingqiu had no time to think about such matters. Her divine consciousness took physical form and rushed toward that tree. Rolling black energy immediately burst forth to resist Chu Qingqiu's power, creating a momentary standoff.

Wasn't Ning Fuyi already reborn? Why was there still such a demonic thing within her body? Chu Qingqiu gritted her teeth to control her divine consciousness, but was induced to develop a headache herself.

In the end, this demonic tree actually began to devour her divine consciousness.

At this critical moment, the other tree suddenly overflowed with wisps of pink power. Immortal power flowed into Chu Qingqiu's divine consciousness, as if helping her.

So Chu Qingqiu silently recited the incantation. With the help of the unfamiliar immortal power, pink energy waves exploded outward with her as the center, and the demonic tree's energy was immediately forced back into its body.

Finally, visibly, those roots that had deeply embedded themselves in Ning Fuyi's sea of consciousness began to slowly withdraw. The cracked demonic fruit healed again, and the demonic energy was re-sealed.

Chu Qingqiu had wanted to destroy this demonic tree in one go, but she could no longer sustain herself. Her divine consciousness was suddenly pushed out of the sea of consciousness. Heat flowed through her spine as she trembled all over and fell beside Ning Fuyi, burying her face in her shoulder and breathing heavily.

Their hands still grasped each other, palms retaining the moist warmth of fine sweat.

The sensation of divine consciousness fusion was too wondrous - as if in that instant, they were like two cups of clear wine completely mixed together, with you in me and me in you.

Even without touching, they could feel every inch of each other's skin.

Chu Qingqiu's body had already softened into a puddle of water, unable and unwilling to move. She curled up on her side next to Ning Fuyi, trembling as she closed her eyes, letting all her tears flow into Ning Fuyi's black hair.

Ning Fuyi's rapid heartbeat from before also gradually calmed. Her lips trembled slightly, the massive impact on her divine consciousness leaving her unable to recover for a long time.

Her head no longer hurt. Misty tears gathered at the corners of her eyes, and a cold tear slid from her eye corner, flowing all the way to the pillow's edge.

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The night grew deeper. Several stars hung in the night sky, and fallen leaves rustled onto the eaves. After accumulating into a pile, they fell together with a pattering sound.

Chu Qingqiu finally recovered some strength. She supported herself on the bed edge to sit up, her body aching as if beaten. She removed the hairpin still stuck in her disheveled hair, letting down countless soft strands.

She used the fastest speed to extract herself from desire and restore her composure.

This was the first time she had personally directed dual cultivation techniques. Being her first attempt, she hadn't done it well.

She lifted her sleeve with her hand and discovered a shallow red mark had appeared on her wrist at some point. She stroked the red mark, wanting it to fade, but for some reason it couldn't dissipate.

Finally, she had to give up, covering it with her sleeve. She weakly got out of bed, her wide robes trailing at her feet. After taking two unsteady steps, she looked back at Ning Fuyi.

The woman still lay motionless in the same place, obviously still unconscious. She breathed a sigh of relief and pushed the door to walk into the night.

"Divine Venerable!" Jiang Li emerged from the bushes again, still topped with grass leaves. After looking around, she quickly ran to Chu Qingqiu and raised her hand to drape a cloak over her shoulders.

Chu Qingqiu was quite weak at this moment. The cloak nearly made her collapse, so she quickly circulated her power to calm her scattered divine consciousness before standing steady.

"Why are you acting like a thief? I'm dual cultivating, not having an affair," Chu Qingqiu discovered some blood traces still remained at her lips and wiped them with her fingertip.

"I'm not - I was afraid someone might see Divine Venerable disheveled and gossip," Jiang Li looked more excited than Chu Qingqiu. She grasped her right hand with her left and asked, "Is it complete?"

"Mm." Chu Qingqiu grasped the corners of her cloak and wrapped herself tightly. "I just couldn't remove that demonic tree, only re-sealed it."

"Sealing it is good. I'll research how to uproot that thing later," Jiang Li breathed a sigh of relief and smiled as she supported Chu Qingqiu. "Look, Divine Venerable's nose tip is red - quite pitiable and lovable."

"Jiang Li!" Chu Qingqiu couldn't bear it anymore and tried to pull away her hand, dragging her unsteady steps toward the Tranquil Mountain Palace¹.

"She fainted before seeing me. Please take care of Mo Qihuai - don't mention this matter to her."

"Alright." Jiang Li shook her head and plucked the grass leaves from her head, slowly following behind.

Day and night alternated, and dawn broke.

Strange fragments appeared in her mind again - all intimate scenes she dared not look at directly. Uninhabited vast mountains and rivers, a bamboo house that looked familiar no matter how she looked at it, a small hillside, fragrant flower forests, and a beauty bathed in golden light under the bright sun.

She couldn't see the beauty's face clearly no matter what, yet couldn't get enough of looking.

But dreams would eventually end and be forgotten. With several bird calls outside the window, she suddenly opened her eyes, her mind empty.

She used her hand to shield the sunlight, squinting as she climbed up from bed, looking down at her disheveled clothes and reaching out to cover her fair skin.

Was this the feeling after divine consciousness fusion? Her whole body had that tingling, comfortable sensation of relaxing in hot water all night - both satisfied and comfortable.

Her eyes were somewhat sore from crying, and her cracked lips had formed scabs. She stared at her palm for a moment, then lifted her sleeve to her nose.

A faint, undispersed gardenia fragrance - whether truly lingering or her imagination, she didn't know. But regardless of the reason, she closed her eyes, her tongue brushing over her lips, unconsciously revealing a shallow, faint smile.

Footnotes:

¹ **Tranquil Mountain Palace (静山宫)** - Chu Qingqiu's residence, likely located on a secluded mountain peak befitting her status as a divine venerable